

STUDENT SESSION • THE COMET

The Fact Desk



Name: _____ Class: _____ Date: _____

MEMO — from Deja, editor-in-chief of The Comet: "Welcome to the fact desk. You're hired. Three of our writers used an AI helper on their drafts. Heads up: AI predicts *likely* words — it doesn't check them — so it can be flat-out wrong in a totally confident voice. Nothing runs until your desk clears it."

Your method, every draft: **1. UNDERLINE** every checkable claim (names, dates, numbers, places, quotes). **2. RANK** — write **C** above claims to CHECK, **S** above SAFE ones. **3. LATERAL-READ** — log where a second, independent source could confirm each C. **4. VERDICT** — stamp it, back it up, and say whether the writer's big conclusion still stands once the facts are fixed.

DRAFT #1 — PRIYA'S SCIENCE COLUMN, "MOON FACTS"

The Moon is Earth's only natural satellite. Astronauts first landed on the Moon in 1959, and Neil Armstrong was the first person to walk on its surface. In total, twelve people have walked on the Moon. On a clear night the Moon seems to shine because it produces its own light — which is why it's the brightest thing in the night sky.

CLAIM I MARKED C (CHECK)	SECOND SOURCE: WHERE I'D VERIFY IT

Verdict (circle one): RUN (clean) · FIX (correct it, then run) · KILL (cut the story) — **Note to Priya (your evidence):**

 DRAFT #2 — THEO’S QUIZ PAGE, “WORLD RECORDS CORNER”

The Pacific Ocean is the largest ocean on Earth. The Nile River flows north through Egypt and is one of the longest rivers in the world. The tallest mountain above sea level is Mount Everest, which rises in the Andes range in South America. Earth has seven continents, and the largest is Asia. Australia's capital city is Sydney. Put it together and the record-holders sit on three continents: Africa, South America, and Asia.

CLAIM I MARKED C (CHECK)	SECOND SOURCE: WHERE I'D VERIFY IT

Verdict (circle one): RUN · FIX · KILL — **Note to Theo (your evidence):**

 DRAFT #3 — MARCUS’S FEATURE, “THE INVENTION ISSUE”

Thomas Edison invented the telephone in 1876. As Edison put it, "The telephone is the finest of all my inventions." The next year, in 1877, Edison invented the phonograph — the first machine that could both record and play back sound. A generation later, the Wright brothers made the first successful powered airplane flights in 1903, near Kitty Hawk, North Carolina. That record makes Edison the most important inventor of the 1800s.

CLAIM I MARKED C (CHECK)	SECOND SOURCE: WHERE I'D VERIFY IT

Verdict (circle one): RUN · FIX · KILL — **Note to Marcus (your evidence):**

 EXIT TICKET — CLOCK OUT

1. In your own words: how can AI sound 100% sure and still be wrong?
2. Name one claim you saw online this week (or one you expect to see). What exact lateral-reading move would you make — where's your second, independent source?

Desk rule to keep: smooth is not the same as true. Before you repeat it, post it, or hand it in — clear it.